curement of millets and various forest produce at support price, subsidies to paddy farmers and cash assistance to landless agriculture labour. In Rajasthan, Gehlot hopes to make a comeback on the back of schemes like the Chiranjeevi Health Insurance offering coverage of up to Rs 25 lakh, Annapurna food kits, hike in old-age pensions, free power up to 100 units, revival of OPS and free mobiles to young and single women.

However, the BJP has one more ace now to woo the significant women vote in these states—the recently passed Women's Reservation Bill. In MP, women-centric schemes account for a third of the state's budget for 2023-24. CM Chouhan is also placing his bets on the Ladli Behna Yojana (LBY), under which nearly 130 million women are paid Rs 1,250 per month with a promise that the amount would go up to Rs 3,000. LBY beneficiaries will also get gas cylinders at Rs 450, to blunt the Congress's offer of LPG cylinders for Rs 500. The focus on women is evident in Rajasthan, too, where they outperformed men in voter turnout last time. Gehlot has announced Rs 10,000 a year to every woman head of family and increased coverage of the subsidised LPG cylinder for Rs 500.

UNLIKE BJP, WHERE PM MODI HIMSELF IS LEADING THE CHARGE, CONGRESS IS LETTING STATE SATRAPS DIRECT CAMPAIGNS

To counter the BJP's women-centric initiatives, the Congress is reiterating its demand for separate reservation for OBC women within the larger quota for women and highlighting how the Modi government has hoodwinked the nation by linking the implementation of women's reservation with delimitation.

HINDUTVA VS SOFT HINDUTVA

Even as it plays up a development agenda backed by social welfarism, the BJP does not hesitate to use Hindutva-based polarisation, particularly in states with a significant Muslim population. The Congress campaign got almost derailed in the run-up to the Karnataka polls, when its manifesto said the party would ban the Bajrang Dal if voted to power. PM Modi and other BJP leaders painted it as an insult to Lord Hanuman, also known as Bajrang Bali.

This time, too, the BJP has tried to whip up a polarising narrative in the three states around communally volatile incidents such as the Ramnavami violence in MP's Khargone in April last year, the beheading of a Hindu tailor by two Muslim men in Rajasthan in June 2022, the tension between tribals and Christians in Chhattisgarh over conversions as well as Hindu-Muslim violence in the state. In all three states, however, the local Congress leadership has been careful not to let the BJP run away with the Hindutva plank. Asked if the MP Congress had any plans to ban the Bajrang Dal, state Congress president Kamal Nath promptly said no. Again, when asked if he backed Dhirendra Shastri's call for a Hindu rashtra, the veteran Congressman went a step ahead and said that with an 82 per cent Hindu population, India was already a Hindu rashtra. Then, when DMK leader Udayanidhi Stalin created a stir with his comments on Sanatana Dharma, Nath declined to hold the first joint rally of INDIA in Bhopal to avoid getting dragged into controversy.

In Chhattisgarh, Baghel is trying to counter Hindutva by invoking regional pride or Chhattisgarhiyavaad. He has announced public holidays for local festivals, promoted local games and cuisine and introduced a state song and icon. His government has also taken up projects like Ram Van Gaman Path, Ramayana festivals, built Ram, Sita and Lakshman statues and restored the Mata Kaushalya temple in Raipur.

CHHATTISGARH



OBC FACE

Arun Sao

State unit chief and RSS veteran Arun Sao, who comes from the Sahu community, the largest OBC group in the state, is perceived to be the successor to former chief minister Raman Singh



LONE RANGER

Raman Singh

The three-time CM no longer enjoys the confidence of the central leadership. Singh is fighting to stay relevant, and a good result in the polls, for him and the party, could change things around



THE TRIBAL QUEEN

Renuka Singh Saruta

The Union minister has been asked to contest the assembly polls. She is the party's most popular tribal face

TRUSTED CAMPAIGNERS





Om Mathur and Mansukh Mandaviya

Both leaders are close to PM Modi and have been trying to exploit the anti-incumbency against Congress MLAs rather than challenge CM Bhupesh Baghel